

Teen inventor wins awards for technology that could save kids' lives

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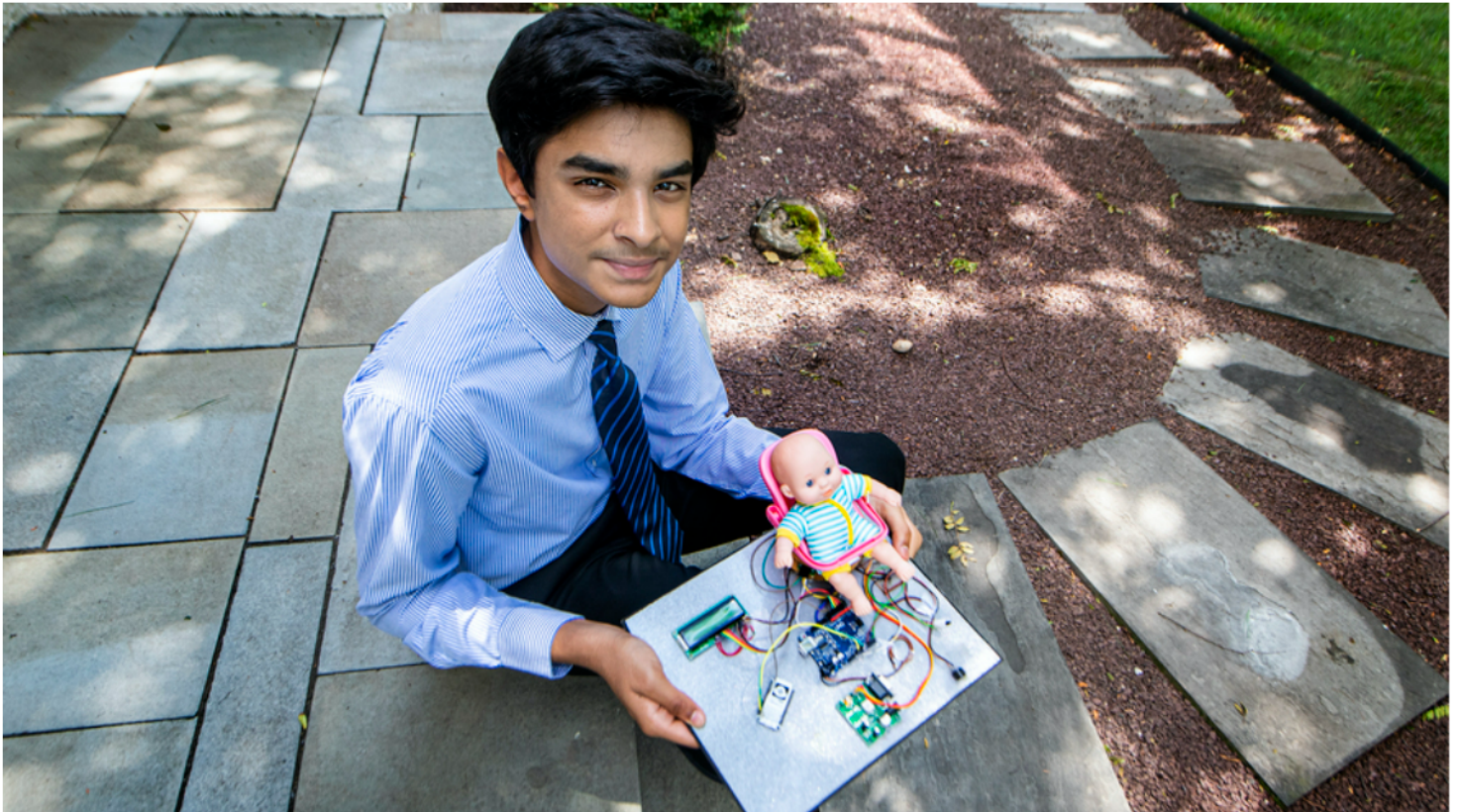


Image 1. Pranavh Joshua Vallabhaneni with his Baby Saver prototype invention at his home in Chadds Ford, Pennsylvania, on August 7, 2020. Vallabhaneni, who is entering his sophomore year at Unionville High School, won first place in his grade category and also the Safety Award for his invention, Baby Saver - Hot Car Alert Device from Invention Convention Worldwide. Photo: Jose F. Moreno/The Philadelphia Inquirer/TNS

Pranavh Joshua Vallabhaneni is 15 years old. He lives in Kennett Square, Pennsylvania. He has a younger brother named Jayden, who is 4 years old. Before Jayden was born, Pranavh's family shopped for car seats and other baby products.

"I realized that there was a lot of emphasis on child safety," Pranavh said. This realization gave him an inventive idea.

Pranavh kept hearing sad stories about babies being left in hot cars. The inside of a car can heat up very quickly, and this can cause an illness called heatstroke, which can be deadly. More than 940 children have died in hot cars across the country since 1990. There were 53 deaths in 2019.

Pranavh was determined to find a way to stop car deaths among babies and young children. "I started to think about why and how to help prevent the issue," Pranavh said.

Car Temperature Triggers Alerts

More than half of the hot-car child deaths were due to parents forgetting their children in cars, Pranavh said. He realized that forgetting could happen to anyone, even his own family. He couldn't imagine something so awful.

Pranavh began working on an invention that warns people when they leave a child in the car. He came up with the Baby Saver Hot Car Alert Device. The device sends warning signals when the temperature inside the car reaches certain thresholds. A threshold is a level or a point that acts as a trigger. In this case, when the temperature in the car reaches a certain degree, it triggers an alert to parents and authorities.

"There was a lot of experimentation that took place to get to the finished model," he said. Experimentation is the process of running tests or trials.

At the first level, an alert will be sent to the parents' cellphones. At the second level, a buzzer will sound in the car to draw attention to the vehicle. At the third level, an alert will be sent to local authorities. The alert will tell the authorities where the car is and that there could be an emergency.

The Invention Won Two Awards

Pranavh said that the temperature levels were easily configurable. When an item is configurable it can be changed to suit the user's needs. The levels could also be adjusted based on location.



Pranavh started working on the idea in his science class. He entered his invention in the Invention Convention Worldwide, or ICW for short. It is a worldwide education program that teaches problem-solving and creativity skills.

In 2020, more than 120,000 student inventors competed at local ICW events. Pranavh and 452 other inventors made it to the national final. An awards ceremony was held on July 2. Pranavh scored first place among ninth-grade competitors. He also won first place for the safety award.

"To get recognized is an honor," he said. "I am really grateful to have an opportunity to showcase my invention on a national level."

A Version For Parents To Buy Is The Goal

Pranavh has a lot of work to do before his invention is ready to be used by the public. He is in the process of getting a patent. Patents are licenses. They give ownership of inventions. If an idea or invention is patented, it means that no one else can make, use or sell that invention.

Pranavh plans to contact car makers and security companies. He hopes they will be able to help make the device on a larger scale. He wants to make sure the device does not cost a lot of money to make or buy. That way, most parents and guardians would be able to buy it.

The young scientist has been thrilled with his experience so far.

"It is an amazing feeling, especially seeing how it grew from an idea to a full-blown invention," Pranavh said. He hopes it will save lives and make the world a better place.